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Stages

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Hands Up, Don't Shoot: "Suicide," Black Gun Ownership, and Restoring Black Masculinity on Black Arts Movement Stages

La Donna L. Forsgren

"We know that if we can get the nation to see, say and understand that Black Lives Matter, then every life would stand a chance. Black people are the only humans in this nation ever legally designated, after all, as not human."
—Patrisse Khan-Cullors and Asha Bandele¹

Black activists of the 1960s and '70s advocated a cultural revolution capable of destroying institutional white racism—meaning the systems of oppression that dehumanize, criminalize, exploit, and ultimately kill Black people. Fostering the Black aesthetic was seen as critical to advancing a Black cultural revolution. Black Arts Movement (1965–76) founder LeRoi Jones (later Amiri Baraka) conceptualized the Black aesthetic as a theoretical gun that Black artists could wield in support of everyday Black people. He provides an early statement of this critical thought in his controversial poem, "Black Art" (1965). Baraka writes: "we want 'poems that kill.' / Assassin poems, Poems that shoot / guns. Poems that wrestle cops into alleys / and take their weapons leaving them dead."² Baraka believed the Black aesthetic could galvanize the Black community to kill their oppressors and reclaim their power. The National Black Theatre (1968–present) founder Barbara Ann Teer theorized that theatre, more than any other art form, offered the best opportunity for fostering this cultural revolution: "theater is a form which can encompass nearly all our creative endeavors. It can disavow all the stereotypes and replace them with more meaningful images that represent us as we really are in life. We must establish for ourselves what . . . is really meaningful to us."³ Theatre also provided an important means for Black activists to urge Black audiences to take responsibility for action and justice within their communities.

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¹ The epigraph is from Patrisse Khan-Cullors and Asha Bandele, *When They Call You a Terrorist: A Black Lives Matter Memoir* (New York: St. Martin's Griffin, 2017), 205.

² Amiri Baraka, "Black Art," in *Black Fire: An Anthology of Afro-American Writing*, ed. Amiri Baraka and Larry Neal (Baltimore: Black Classic Press, 2007 [1968]), 302.

³ Barbara Ann Teer, "We Should Be What We Were Born to Be," *New York Times*, July 7, 1968.

Black women activists were at the forefront of this cultural revolution that was taking place on theatrical stages, reimagining the centrality of Black women's subjectivity—their experiential knowledge, concerns, and desires—within the framework of the Black liberation struggle. For example, activists Sonia Sanchez, Lola E. Jones, and Carol Freeman stood among a cadre of artists-activists who used their creative talents to advocate for Black women without in any way negating concern for the collective well-being of Black families.⁴ Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman formulated new images of Black womanhood to demonstrate the complexities of Black women, their unique experiences of injustice, and the need for their ongoing leadership within Black political mobilization efforts.⁵ However, in celebrating Black women's deep commitment to the survival of Black families, Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman also issue a call for spectators to realize a more inclusive vision of Black liberation. Unfortunately, biases within the academy have amplified masculine-centered visions of Black liberation while simultaneously contributing to the erasure of Black women theatre artists' more nuanced approach to the Black liberation struggle.

While celebrated and, at times, criticized by their peers, Sanchez's, Jones's, and Freeman's woman-centered works faded into obscurity following the decline of the Black Arts Movement. Sanchez, perhaps the most recognizable name among these three Black women artists today, commanded respect from her comrades, but also ran afoul of some Black nationalists men who challenged her woman-centered writings. Sanchez recalls one instance while working in the attic of Baraka's Black Arts Repertory Theatre/School (BART/S, 1965) when a male "comrade" held a gun to her head and demanded that she cease writing.⁶ Despite this threat to her life, Sanchez continued to publish works that center Black women. Jones, a short-story writer, playwright, and English professor, did not achieve the national reputation of either Sanchez or Freeman. However, her woman-centered dramas energized the Black revolution on college campuses across the country.⁷ Freeman, a Louisiana native and Oakland resident, rose to national prominence as an award-winning poet of the Black Arts Movement. *The Suicide*, her only published play, represents the sole Black woman dramatist's voice in Baraka and Larry Neal's seminal collection, *Black Fire* (1968). As a self-described "revolutionary Black nationalist," Freeman's poetry and drama invoke lynching and Black women's mourning to provoke collective action.⁸

By failing to attend to the revolutionary dramas of Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman, we have lost an opportunity to elucidate the political thought of Black women artists of the Black Power era. Their work provides a foundation for understanding the devel-

⁴While Carol Freeman published only one drama, *The Suicide* (1966), Sonia Sanchez and Lola E. Jones each published five plays during the Black Arts Movement. Sanchez wrote *The Bronx Is Next* (1968), *Sister Son/ji* (1969), *Dirty Hearts* (1971), *Malcom/Man Don't Live Here No Mo'* (1972), and *Uh, Uh; But How Do It Free Us?* (1974). Jones's dramatic works include *Helen* (1965), *The Other Side of the Wall* (1965), *The Places of Wrath* (1965), *The Deal* (1976), and *The New Nigger, or Who's Afraid of William Faulkner?* (1976).

⁵For more information about Black women's leadership during the Black Power era, see Ashley D. Farmer's *Remaking Black Power: How Black Women Transformed an Era* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2017).

⁶Sonia Sanchez, personal interview with the author, June 30, 2010.

⁷For more information about Black revolutions on US college campuses during the 1960s and '70s, see Martha Biondi's *The Black Revolution on Campus* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2014).

⁸Amiri Baraka and Larry Neal, eds., *Black Fire: An Anthology of Afro-American Writing*, 3rd ed. (Baltimore: Black Classics Press, 2007), 661. Citations refer to this edition.

opment of Black women's social activism today. Systemic racism and sexism within the academy has led, and continues to lead, to the marginalization of Black women artists within theatre history scholarship. While their works have been less studied or entirely ignored by theatre historians, the revolutionary dramas of Sanchez, Freeman, and Jones made profound contributions to Black Power and Black feminist discourses. In this essay, I examine the discourses in Sanchez's *The Bronx Is Next* (1968), Jones's *The New Nigger, or Who's Afraid of William Faulkner* (1976), and Freeman's *The Suicide* (1966) in order to illuminate that collectively, their works demonstrate that "none of us are free until all of us are free," a mantra that women leaders of the Black Lives Matter movement (2013–present) have now embraced.⁹

The second part of this essay explores the symbolic relationship among race, gender, and gun violence in four revolutionary dramas of the Black Arts Movement. I begin by exploring Baraka's *Arm Yourself, Or Harm Yourself* (1967), a play that engages with the Black Power rhetoric of gun ownership, hegemonic masculinity, and white-authored gun violence. I then consider Sanchez's, Jones's, and Freeman's engagements with Baraka's representative work. I situate their (at times) controversial dramas within Black women's long-standing activist tradition, examining how their works produce womanist thought that complicates Black Power rhetoric of self-defense and masculinist understandings of Black liberation. By "womanist," I refer to the Black feminist term coined by Alice Walker in her book, *In Search of Our Mother's Gardens: Womanist Prose* (1983). Walker writes that a womanist "loves other women, sexually and/or nonsexually. Appreciates and prefers women's culture, women's emotional flexibility (values tears as natural counterbalance of laughter), and women's strength. Sometimes loves individual men, sexually and/or nonsexually. Committed to the survival and wholeness of entire people, male and female."¹⁰ While the works of women dramatists of the Black Arts Movement pre-date Walker's Black feminist theorization; their dramas nonetheless provide an early expression of womanist thought. In detailing how the Black Arts Movement was less uniformly masculinist than it has sometimes been depicted, I also demonstrate how Sanchez's, Jones's, and Freeman's early womanist interventions laid a critical foundation for the principles outlined by Black women activists who lead today's Black Lives Matter movement.

Arm Yourself, or Harm Yourself: Black Masculinity and the Theatre of Assault

History has shown that white-authored violence has been one of the most effective ways to maintain white male supremacy and Black subjugation. During chattel slavery, guns were exclusively a white male prerogative. Black men were denied access to guns to prevent enslaved Blacks from escaping or leading insurrections that would devastate an economy built on their labor. Following emancipation, white male supremacy

⁹ White-authored violence takes many forms, negatively impacting the physical, psychological, and economic well-being of Black people. Denying Black people access to a basic human habitat—clear air, water, shelter, and food—is a form of white-authored violence. Socializing Black children to believe in their own inferiority is a form of white-authored violence. Policing Black people—their speech, gaze, and body—is a form of white-authored violence. Denying Black people access to doctors, home ownership, a living wage—white-authored violence. Thus white-authored violence can occur before a literal shot is fired.

¹⁰ Alice Walker, *In Search of Our Mother's Gardens: Womanist Prose* (San Diego: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1983), xi.

flourished as Jim Crow laws enabled them to use guns to patrol, imprison, and lynch Black people for even the most minor violations. By the 1960s, many Black activists perceived the gun as an extension of violent white patriarchy. The former Black Panther Party (1966–82) newspaper editor-in-chief Judy Juanita remembers:

I chose activism because I had seen and heard about police oppression in Oakland. My earliest memories of the police and their interaction with Black people were very traumatic scenes of big, white men being menacing figures in blue uniforms to Black people. I have seen more than enough spread-eagled young Black men on the ground next to police cars. So, I knew that what the Panthers were talking about was true.¹¹

Juanita's recollection situates white police officers as looming beasts who hunt, immobilize, and degrade Black men under the guise of arrest. Unfortunately, these daily interactions do escalate, resulting in the extrajudicial murders of Black people.

The impetus for Black Arts Movement theatre emerged from mass demonstrations against white-authored shootings of Black people. Indeed, the 1960s witnessed hundreds of race-related uprisings—often incited by white police officers shooting unarmed Black men and boys—throughout major US cities.¹² For example, the Harlem uprisings of 1964 were sparked by the death of a Black 15-year-old named James Powell, a Bronx resident who was shot and killed by a white police officer in front of witnesses outside of an apartment building. Hundreds of Powell's classmates gathered to protest his fatal shooting, followed by six consecutive nights of demonstrations by thousands of Harlem residents. As extrajudicial shootings persisted throughout the country, rebellions continued. The summer of 1967, known as the "Long, Hot Summer of 1967," proved particularly volatile, resulting in 159 race-related uprisings across the United States. These rebellions stirred a generation of theatre artists, including Baraka, to create Black art that would sustain the hearts, minds, and souls of Black Americans.

Baraka's founding of BART/S in 1965 turned long-standing Black political thought into action, providing a space for Black artists and activists to commune and realize the artistic vision articulated in his manifesto, "The Revolutionary Theatre" (1965). In this text, Baraka describes revolutionary theatre as nourishment for the souls of Black folk, as well as a vital tool for protecting Black communities from all forms of white-authored violence.¹³ "The Revolutionary Theatre . . . must be food for all those who need food, and daring propaganda for the Beauty of the Human Mind. But it is a political theatre, a weapon to help in the slaughter of these dimwitted fat-bellied white guys who somehow believe that the rest of the world is here to slobber on," writes Baraka.¹⁴ As a rhetorical weapon, revolutionary dramas functioned as a source of nourishment intended to "feed" Black minds heretofore starved of their own his-

¹¹ Judy Juanita, personal interview with the author, August 14, 2018.

¹² Unfortunately, public discourse continues to focus on the extra-legal murders of Black men and boys, while ignoring or minimizing violence against Black women and girls. For an in-depth investigation of the Black rebellions of the 1960s and '70s, see Elizabeth Hinton's *America on Fire: The Untold History of Police Violence and Black Rebellion since the 1960s* (New York: Liveright, 2021).

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¹⁴ Amiri Baraka, "The Revolutionary Theatre," *Black Dialogue* 1, no. 1 (1965): 5.

tory and culture. As a metaphorical weapon, revolutionary dramas could destroy the slobbering monster: white cultural hegemony.

Baraka envisioned revolutionary dramas as a theatre of assault, as weapons Black artists could wield to expose harsh truths, including the need for Black men to defend themselves and their communities from white male violence. Baraka incorporated guns into his street plays in order to draw spectators, making a spectacle of the symbolic meaning of Black gun ownership. He recalls one occasion when he sent a BART/S troupe member running down the street "with a pistol chasing one of the characters in *Black Ice*. [S]eeing a brother with a gun chasing somebody who looked like a white man made a crowd instantly, and the show began!"¹⁵ Baraka's formulations were in keeping with masculinist Black Power imagery of the time, as exemplified by the highly circulated 1967 image of Black Panther Party leader Huey P. Newton seated in a wicker chair. In the image, Newton stares defiantly at the camera, appearing as a prince on a throne framed by African cultural artifacts. Eschewing a sceptre, Newton holds a shot gun in his right hand and African hunting staff in his left. The image evokes a call to use weapons—Black gun ownership and culture—to restore Black men to their rightful place as kings and princes. Indeed, many Black activists—including members of the Black Panther Party—encouraged Black male gun ownership as an essential step toward reclaiming their "lost" manhood or kingdom. Baraka's formulations tap into Black Panther Party imagery and rhetorical strategies, conceptualizing revolutionary theatre as a viable platform to help restore Black manhood (fig. 1).

The restoration of Black manhood—which some Black Panther Party activists perceived as tantamount to the liberation of Black America—entailed the ability to defend and protect the Black community from white, male-authored violence. Increasing Black male gun ownership became the proposed method of defense and protection, and for some, liberation. The Black Panther Party reinforced this ideology through spectacular displays of Black-male gun ownership during public protests. Many white male politicians, including California's then-governor Ronald Reagan, attempted to disarm the Black Panther Party. For example, one of their most noted protests featured thirty party members marching to the steps of the California State Capitol building armed with .45 caliber pistols, .357 Magnums, and 12-gauge shotguns. Their 1967 display led state politicians to pass the Mulford Act, effectively preventing Panthers from openly carrying loaded firearms during protests and "copwatching" patrols.¹⁶ While politicians may have curtailed their efforts, the Black Panther Party's performances of Black power inspired Black activists and offered much-needed contrast from the all-too-familiar sight of white men leveling guns at stripped, handcuffed, and motionless Black people (fig. 2).

Baraka furthered Black Power rhetoric of self-defense in his one-act play *Arm Yourself, or Harm Yourself* (1967), presenting Black-male gun ownership as the only viable strategy for restoring Black manhood and liberating Black America. The script cover includes a drawing of a white police officer firing a pistol at point-blank range into the back of the head of a Black man kneeling with his raised hands. Weaponless, the Black man surrenders in the same fashion as Missouri resident Michael Brown, who uttered the

¹⁵ Amiri Baraka, *The Autobiography of LeRoi Jones/Amiri Baraka* (New York: zfreundlich Books, 1984), 212.

¹⁶ For more information about the Black Panther Party, see Peniel E. Joseph, ed., *The Black Power Movement: Rethinking the Civil Rights-Black Power Era* (New York: Routledge, 2006).



Figure 1. Huey Newton seated in a wicker chair, 1967. (Photo attributed to Blair Stapp, composition by Eldridge Cleaver, courtesy of Merrill C. Berman Collection.)

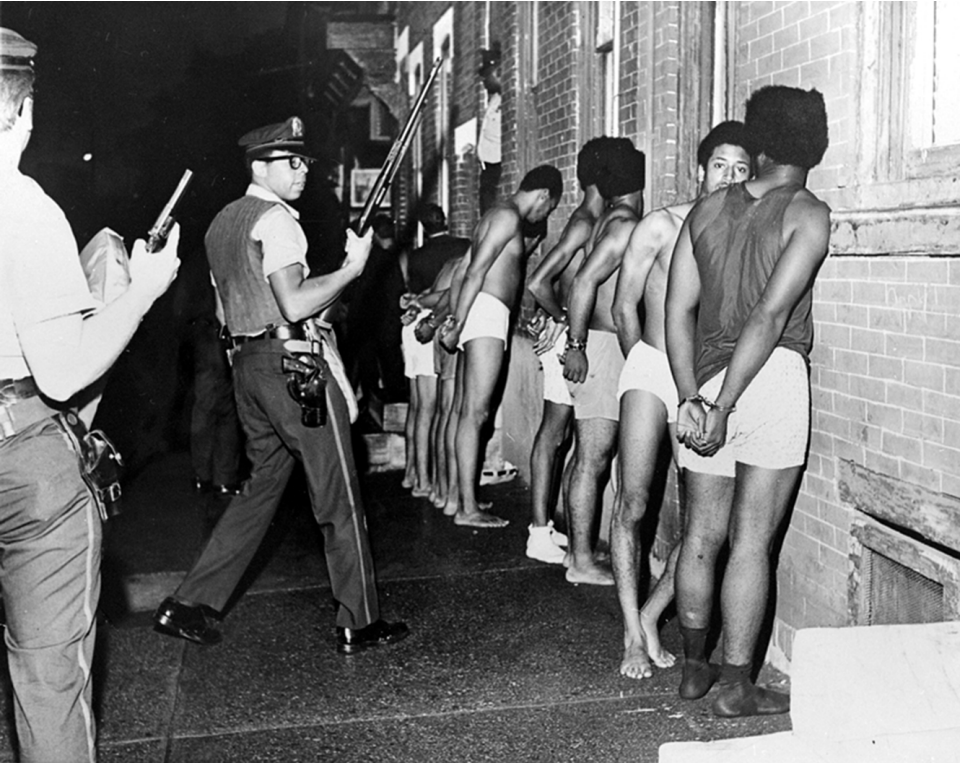


Figure 2. Members of the Black Panther Party stripped, handcuffed, and arrested after Philadelphia police raided the Panther headquarters August 1970. (Photo: Courtesy of the Special Collections Research Center, Temple University Libraries. Philadelphia.)

words “Don’t shoot” before being shot and killed by Ferguson police in 2014. As with Brown, the Black man in the image presents little threat, but meets a similar fate as smoke rises from the officer’s pistol. The play mirrors this outcome: it opens with white male police officers raiding a dwelling occupied by a character called First Brother, an armed activist named Second Brother, an unarmed Sister, and her unarmed husband Paul. Paul attempts to surrender after the police pound on the door, demanding entry and yelling racial slurs. He raises his hands, showing that he is unarmed and already injured. The police officers respond by shooting him in the stomach.

Ultimately, *Arm Yourself* warns that if Black men fail to take up the gun and work cooperatively, they will become victims of white male assault. Incensed by Paul’s murder, First Brother enters a Black nationalist debate with Second Brother about their next course of action. Unarmed, First Brother represents Black male impotence, having accepted the belief that he is powerless to define a better future. In contrast, Second Brother cocks his gun, a symbol of his continued courage, and states: “Ain’t no devil on this planet gonna put his bloody claws on me, brother. Not no more, my man . . . not no more.”¹⁷ His desire to defend himself emerges from his need to reclaim his manhood by protecting those he holds dear. Second Brother defends his more passive

¹⁷ Baraka, *Arm Yourself*, 3.

position, stating, "I'm talking Fire . . . And protecting my family and surviving past these soulless savages. Surviving, man."¹⁸ Second Brother only wants Black people to *survive* white-authored shootings; he cannot envision a world wherein Black people *thrive*. The debate dissolves into fisticuffs, and Sister pleads with the men to stop fighting one another. The play concludes with the white officers bursting through the door, shooting and killing the Black occupants.

Unfortunately, Baraka's perpetuation of hegemonic masculinity *excludes* Black women from the paradigm of capable leadership within the Black liberation struggle. By "hegemonic masculinity," I refer to the hierarchal power structure that uses identities—such as gender, class, sexuality, age, and race—in opposition to one another to empower those closest to dominant social norms while marginalizing those furthest away.¹⁹ The majority of Black men lack access to wealthy white men's political, economic, and social standing. Unable to claim traditional markers of white-defined masculine power, Black men's "use of their bodies, physicality, and a form of masculine aggressiveness becomes more important."²⁰ Physical aggressiveness—dominating Black women, boys, gay men, and poor and working-class men of other races—provided a means of commanding "respect," an essential aspect of Black manhood. In *Arm Yourself*, Second Brother's acquisition of manhood is *dependent* upon Sister's subordination. As such, Sister does not wield a gun, does not engage in the physical altercation between First Brother and Second Brother, and remains voiceless during their Black nationalist debate. When she does speak, she only reinforces her position as a passive victim of white, male-authored violence. For example, Sister explains that Paul's initial injury occurred while exercising his male authority. "The policeman put his hands . . . on me . . . asked me for identification. . . . Paul hit him . . . and he shot Paul," recounts Sister.²¹ First Brother responds to Sister's experience of assault with apathy, which prompts Second Brother to warn him, "until you, we, get enough heart to walk with this power . . . to be men, brother, then we deserve just what we get."²² Second Brother considers the white officer's assault of Sister as an act of "disrespect" toward Black *men*. Therefore taking up the gun ("this power") to protect Black women becomes an important expression of Black manhood. Sister, who is furthest removed from hegemonic masculinity, can only *observe* the Black liberation struggle, not actively participate.

Baraka's production of *Arm Yourself* was not intended to embolden Black women to take up arms and lead the revolution, but rather to inspire Black men to action. The phrase "Arm Yourself, or Harm Yourself," much like today's "Hands Up, Don't Shoot," was a rallying cry during the Black Power era. Baraka uses this Black activist slogan as the title of his work and appends the subtitle, "A Message of Self-Defense to Black Men," explicitly identifying Black men as his target audience and agents of initiating armed resistance. *Arm Yourself* premiered at Spirit House, a theatre charged with at-

¹⁸ Ibid.

¹⁹ For more information about the hierarchal structure of US hegemonic masculinity, see Patricia Hill Collins, *Black Sexual Politics: African Americans, Gender, and the New Racism* (New York: Routledge, 2005), 186.

²⁰ Patricia Hill Collins, *Black Sexual Politics: African Americans, Gender, and the New Racism* (New York: Routledge, 2005), 190.

²¹ Baraka, *Arm Yourself*, 5.

²² Ibid., 7.

tending to the concerns of the Black community of Newark. Baraka penned the play in 1967, as police brutality and shootings of unarmed Black people continued to rise, eventually resulting in the Newark Rebellion that same year. Turning critical thought into action, performances at Spirit House—led by the acting troupe Spirit House Movers—were intended to galvanize the Black community. The theatre historian Harry Elam Jr. describes typical performances:

Performances often occurred in the context of Black protest rallies or events. At these gatherings Baraka would deliver a speech, after which the Spirit House Movers would stage one or more plays. During the protest rally, the Spirit House Movers performed a variety of pre- and post-performance duties—introducing Baraka and the performance, lecturing, reading poetry, handing out literature, leading the spectators in revolutionary chants and cheers.²³

Performed within the context of Newark political activism, *Arm Yourself* did not simply raise awareness of white-authored gun violence; it issued a call-to-arms for *Black men* to reclaim their manhood and protect their communities.

Sister's exclusion from the Black Power debate contradicts the reality that Black women—cis, queer, trans, or otherwise—have *always* been and *continue* to be active agents of social change. In terms of artistic activism, Black women have a long history of using theatre to protest white-authored violence on Black people. During the Harlem Renaissance, Black women activists such as Angelina Weld Grimké, Georgia Douglas Johnson, Mary P. Burrill, and countless others produced a body of anti-lynching plays to raise awareness and incite community action against the extrajudicial murders of Black men, women, and children. Their efforts, and those that came before them, inspired Black women artist-activists of the Black Arts Movement, who in turn fostered a critical womanist intervention within Black Power discourse.

As Black women activists, Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman used their art to create a womanist intervention that refuted much of the masculinist Black Power rhetoric promoted by their male comrades by expanding who was included in the resistance movement. Their efforts, and those of other Black women activists of the era, laid the groundwork for Black women to lead the Black liberation struggle of today. Indeed, the Black Lives Matter movement cofounders Alicia Garza, Opal Tometi, and Patrisse Khan-Cullors use their more inclusive vision of Black liberation within their movement principles. Khan-Cullors recognizes this profound legacy in her memoir *When They Call You a Terrorist: A Black Lives Matter Memoir* (2017). Khan-Cullors and journalist Asha Bandele write: "We do this work today because on another day work was done by Assata Shakur, Angela Davis, Miss Major, the Black Panther Party, the members of the Black Arts Movement, SNCC, the RNA, Malcolm X, Martin Luther King, Ella Baker, and so many others. We owe you and the world a debt of gratitude."²⁴ In recognizing that *none of us are free until all of us are free*, the Black Lives Matter movement attempts to realize its vision of centering the most marginalized voices within Black communities. Garza, Tometi, and Khan-Cullors write that "[w]e affirm the lives of Black queer and trans folks, disabled folks, undocumented folks, folks with records, women, and all Black lives along the gender spectrum. Our network centers those who have been

²³ Harry J. Elam Jr., *Taking It to the Streets: The Social Protest Theater of Luis Valdez and Amiri Baraka* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1997), 102.

²⁴ Khan-Cullors and Bandele, *When They*, 257.



Figure 3. With blood covering her hand and arm, a woman points at a police officer on September 21, 2016 in Charlotte. The North Carolina governor had declared a state of emergency in the city of Charlotte after clashes during protests in response to the fatal shooting by police officers of 43-year-old Keith Lamont Scott at an apartment complex near UNC Charlotte.

(Photo: Sean Rayford, courtesy of Getty Images.)

marginalized within Black liberation movements.”²⁵ Rather than perpetuate Black Power rhetoric that reduces Black liberation to the acquisition of “manhood,” the Black Lives Matter movement locates Black liberation at the nexus of intersectional struggle, and in so doing, creates space to revalue the sanctity of *all* Black lives (fig. 3).

Guns and Bitches: Sonia Sanchez’s Womanist Intervention

Sanchez’s revolutionary drama *The Bronx Is Next* anticipates and actively sets the groundwork for contemporary Black (women) activists and organizers. *The Bronx Is Next* presents a group of young revolutionaries—Charles, Roland, Larry, and Jimmy—on the streets of Harlem, initiating a reverse migration South. As they gather residents to burn down their tenement houses, they converse with an elderly woman who refuses to abandon her belongings, a young mother named Black Bitch, and an empathetic White Cop who solicits sex from Black Bitch. Through their interactions, Sanchez refutes the criminalization of Black men, condemns white-authored shootings of Black men, and promotes Black gun ownership. However, Sanchez adds complexity to Black political thought through her scathing critique of performative white allyship and hegemonic masculinity within the Black liberation struggle. Yet *The Bronx Is Next* ultimately argues for a more radical vision of Black liberation founded upon strong Black families, with Black men and women working together in love, unity, and mutual respect.

²⁵ Alicia Garza, Opal Tometi, and Patrisse Khan-Cullors, “About,” *Black Lives Matter*, available at <https://Blacklivesmatter.com/about/>.

The Bronx Is Next reflects the political concerns and debates that were happening among Black communities in Harlem. Upon the closure of BART/S in 1965, Sanchez left Harlem and moved to the San Francisco Bay area to teach alongside Baraka, Sarah Webster Fabio, Ed Bullins, and Marvin X at San Francisco State College. Along with helping organizers and student activists establish the first Black studies program in the United States, Sanchez published her first play, *The Bronx Is Next*, which premiered at Theatre Black (New York) in 1970.²⁶ *The Bronx Is Next* dramatizes the Republic of New Afrika's (1968–present) vision of establishing an independent Black nation in five US Southern states: Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, Mississippi, and South Carolina. According to Sanchez, the Nation of Islam had already purchased land in the South, and revolutionary leaders had begun endorsing burning down tenement houses as a way of securing livable public housing.²⁷ Elizabeth Hinton writes that securing safe and habitable public housing was a significant concern of this era, as “the cycle of police violence and Black rebellion in the late 1960s and early 1970s often started in, and consumed, public housing areas.”²⁸ *The Bronx Is Next* takes audiences directly to this battleground: the streets of Harlem.

The Bronx Is Next exposes the everyday occurrences of white men policing, assaulting, and killing Black people through the character Jimmy. During the process of removing tenants, Jimmy turns to his cadre and states: “Do you know that jest yesterday I was running down my ghetto street and these two white dudes stopped me and asked what I was doing out so early in the morning—and cuz I was high off some smoke—I said man—it’s my street—I can walk on it any time. And they grabbed me and told me where everything was.”²⁹ Similar to the Black men in *Arm Yourself*, Jimmy describes a situation in which he found himself a potential victim of white male-authored violence (“And they grabbed me and told me where everything was”). Although Black people are often socialized to behave in a submissive manner when approached by white men, “smoke” dulled Jimmy’s sense of danger, making his behavior anything but compliant. By asserting his manhood and staking a claim to “his” street (or Black communal spaces), Jimmy ran afoul with “two white dudes.” He does not distinguish whether they are white police officers or white vigilantes, suggesting that perhaps they are the same. While Jimmy lived to tell his tale, this was not the case for generations of Black Americans who experienced a similar form of white terrorism.³⁰

The Bronx Is Next also reveals the dangers of performative white allyship through White Cop’s interactions with the revolutionaries. When Charles blames “a difference in color” for hindering Black social mobility, White Cop responds: “Poverty of the mind and spirit. Why? Things are so much better. All it takes is a little more effort from you people. But these riots. It’s making good people have second thoughts about everything.”³¹ As one of the “good people,” White Cop implies that he counts himself

²⁶ As of this publication, there is no extant evidence of the premiere production of *The Bronx Is Next*. However, lack of archival evidence is not unusual for the era, as many documents have been lost, accidentally destroyed, or housed in inaccessible private collections.

²⁷ Sanchez, personal interview.

²⁸ Hinton, *America on Fire*, 70.

²⁹ Sonia Sanchez, “The Bronx Is Next,” *TDR: The Drama Review* 12, no. 4 (1968): 80.

³⁰ The history of lynching has shown that white police officers did not curtail white vigilantes. Rather, many police officers spearheaded, participated in, and turned a blind eye to the extralegal killings of Black men, a practice that continues today. For more information, see Patricia A. Young’s “Acts of Terrorism, or, Violence on ‘Sunday Morning in the South,’” *MELUS* 26, no. 4 (2001): 25–39.

³¹ Sanchez, “The Bronx Is Next,” 80.

among the white liberals who support greater equality. However, his misguided speech ignores the impact of institutional white racism and instead blames lack of willpower as the contributing factor for poverty within Black communities. He also polices the tone the Black activists use, suggesting a “right” and “wrong” way to protest shootings. Rebelling in the streets—one of the few spaces Black people can occupy—is deemed unacceptable for his white liberal sensibilities.

Sanchez continues to explore the limits of white allyship through a surreal reenactment of white-authored gun violence. After Jimmy shares his experience, the revolutionaries convince White Cop to pretend to be a Black man running through the streets of Harlem. The revolutionaries, acting as white police officers, stop and interrogate White Cop for stealing:

WHITE COP: I haven't stolen anything. I haven't anything in my pockets. *Goes into his pockets.*

JIMMY: *(Draws gun)* Get your hands out your pockets boy. Against the wall right now.

WHITE COP: But what have I done? I was just running. This is not legal you know. You have no right to do this . . .

ROLAND: You are perfectly correct. We have no right to do this. Why I even have no right to hit you but I am. *(Hits WHITE COP with gun. WHITE COP falls down)*³²

This scene demonstrates an imbalance of power consistent with real life: most everyday Black citizens do not wield guns, whereas police officers surely do. As a newly rendered Black man, White Cop fails to understand that possession of firearms determines the outcome of events, leaving unarmed Black civilians at the mercy of armed police officers. Vocalizing the illegality of racial profiling (that is, Black people steal) and his rights as a citizen only provoke more violence. As a newly minted Black man, White Cop has not been socialized to understand that “racial profiling is based on . . . the *potential* threat caused by African American men's bodies.”³³ Therefore the simple act of bodily movement results in “white” men drawing their guns. Now fearing for his life, White Cop pleads, “I'm ready to stop—I'm tired.”³⁴ Of course, Black people are also “tired” of police shootings and want to eradicate all forms of white-authored violence, but this has yet to happen. The revolutionaries disregard White Cop's desire to “stop” and restore normative hierarchies of power. Instead, they emasculate White Cop, calling him a “nigger boy” as they whip him with their guns. Through this role reversal and pistol-whipping, the revolutionaries assert their masculinity and reveal another painful truth: white allies would never willingly choose to be a Black person in America and face gun violence for doing something as simple as running.

Sanchez's womanist intervention supports Black male agency and gun ownership, but critiques the revolutionaries' limited vision of both Black masculinity and Black liberation through their treatment of Black Bitch. When Black Bitch refuses to join their trek South, Charles asserts his “manhood” by kissing her and declaring: “I could fuck you right here if I wanted to. You know what a Black man is don't you bitch? Is that what happens when you fuck faggoty white men?”³⁵ At this moment, Charles reifies hegemonic masculinity and, in so doing, maintains the structures that marginalize Black women, girls, trans, queer, and gender-nonconforming people within Black com-

³² Ibid., 81.

³³ Collins, *Black Sexual Politics*, 153.

³⁴ Sanchez, “The Bronx Is Next,” 81.

³⁵ Ibid., 82.

munities. Black Bitch questions Charles's patriarchal notions of control and dominance: "I know what I am . . . But all you revolutionaries or nationalists or whatever you call yourselves—do you know where you at? I am a Black woman and I've had Black men who could not love me or my Black boys—where you gonna find Black women to love you when all this is over—when you need them?"³⁶ Rather than listen to her concerns, the so-called revolutionaries beat and humiliate her, silencing her in order to clear the way for their vision of Black liberation. The irony is that by exploiting her vulnerability, the revolutionaries do not treat Black Bitch any differently than White Cop. Discarded by the revolutionaries, Black Bitch and her children remain alone, poor, and vulnerable to white-authored violence.

The Bronx Is Next, written more than fifty years ago, reveals an enduring truth: white-authored violence can happen at any time, anywhere, for any "reason." In other words, Black lives are neither valued nor protected in this country. Sanchez affirmed this belief during our 2010 interview in her home in Philadelphia: "The thing about these plays: they were reflecting what was going on in the world, but at the same time we were also making a statement about it too. It's still happening today. Young Blacks get killed constantly if they're out at a certain time of night. If you're a Black person—especially a male—you cannot be out on the streets of any major city not knowing where you're going to. If you do, you die."³⁷ Long before technology could record the dangers of "running while Black," Sanchez used her craft for bearing witness to this problem. The more recent shooting of Ahmaud Arbery serves as a stark reminder that running through the streets remains just as dangerous for Black men today as it was in 1968.³⁸

Finally, *The Bronx Is Next* provides a warning for contemporary Black activists to beware of self-appointed white allies and those who would try to define the limits of Black liberation. While White Cop does not utter the phrase "peaceful protest," I cannot help but consider how his speech resonates with the debates I witnessed in the wake of the Black Lives Matter movement demonstrations during the summer of 2020. I read numerous social media posts from liberal white friends, politicians, and celebrities, which all essentially stated, "Police shootings are terrible, but destroying property is just as bad." These comments lead me to surmise that for some, *property* holds as much value as Black life. Furthermore, Black activists must recognize the needs of the most vulnerable populations—Black mothers, sex workers, and so on. If we fail to recognize our own humanity, specialness, and right to exist, how can we possibly get the nation to see, say, and understand that Black Lives Matter?

A Black Girl Shall Lead Them: Lola E. Jones's Womanist Intervention

Jones's *The New Nigger, or Who's Afraid of William Faulkner* also engages with Black political debates of the time, using satire to reveal the dangers of not imagining Black liberation beyond what white men define as "success." In so doing, Jones reveals the absurdity of Black male bravado and makes the deadly serious argument that if

³⁶ Ibid.

³⁷ Sanchez, personal interview.

³⁸ On February 23, 2020, 25-year-old Ahmaud Arbery was hunted and killed by two armed white men in a pickup truck while he was jogging in his south Georgia neighborhood. With the case still pending, many details of the murder remain unknown. However, we do know Arbery was killed with Travis McMichael's shotgun and that he used a racial slur moments before firing. For more information, see Richard Fausset's "What We Know about the Shooting Death of Ahmaud Arbery," *New York Times*, December 17, 2020, available at <https://www.nytimes.com/article/ahmaud-arbery-shooting-georgia.html>.

Black men continue to ignore the concerns of Black women and girls, the revolution is bound to fail.

The New Nigger serves as a counterargument to Nobel Prize-winner William Faulkner's infamous commentary about racial integration and white-male gun culture. During his 1956 interview with journalist Russell Warren Howe, Faulkner remarked: "The South is armed for revolt. After the Supreme Court decision [of May 17, 1954, on school integration] you couldn't get as much as a few rounds for a deer rifle in Mississippi. The gunsmiths were sold out. These white people will accept another Civil War knowing they're going to lose."³⁹ Later, Faulkner admits that although he would prefer navigating the "middle of the road," he would "fight for Mississippi against the United States even if it meant going out into the street and shooting Negroes."⁴⁰ Faulkner uses "South" and "Mississippi" as dog-whistle terms for the Southern white men who fear and resist integration as ardently as their ancestors feared and resisted emancipation. Responding to this perceived Black threat, everyday white men took up arms, endowing themselves with the power to kill Black people. Faulkner suggests that the answer to white terrorism lies in giving white men "time" to come to terms with integration: "Give him time—don't force us. . . . Things have been getting better slowly for a long time. Only six Negroes were killed by whites in Mississippi last year, according to the police figures."⁴¹ The absurdity of phrases such as "things are getting better," "only six Negroes were killed by whites," and "police records" were not lost on Black intellectuals of the time. James Baldwin famously counterargued that one Black death at the hands of whites was too many, questioned the accuracy of police accounts, and insisted that many Southern Black men were not "afraid of changing the status quo."⁴² *The New Nigger* supports Baldwin's counterargument, demonstrating that Southern Blacks are not "afraid" of the world's Faulkners or white male vigilantes. *The New Nigger* depicts Southern Black men ready to take up arms in pursuit of racial integration.

At the time of the play's publication, the racial integration of public schools had been in effect for twenty years. As a professor at the historically Black university Morgan State and having taught English in her hometown of Norfolk, Virginia (1954–62), Charlottesville (1962–63), and Baltimore (1963–67), Jones had experienced the consequences of *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954). While there is little evidence to suggest *The New Nigger* was produced, Jones clearly wanted audiences to consider several key questions: Was integration the most viable solution to counteract white terrorism? Did integration liberate Black people, including Black women and girls? What fundamental changes are still needed to liberate all Black people?⁴³ Ultimately, the play answers these and other questions with a call to redefine the meaning of Black liberation.

Similar to Sanchez, Jones's womanist intervention condemns white-authored shootings of Black people and exposes detrimental behaviors that weaken the Black liberation struggle. However, Jones deviates from Sanchez's method of critique in her use of satire to expose the dangers of hegemonic masculinity and exclusive Black male leadership.

³⁹ Russell Warren Howe, "A Talk with William Faulkner," *The Reporter*, March 22, 1956, 18.

⁴⁰ *Ibid.*, 19.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 18.

⁴² James Baldwin, "Faulkner and Desegregation," *Partisan Review* 23, no. 4 (1956): 569–70.

⁴³ *The Other Side of the Wall* premiered at the Norfolk Public Library Cultural Center on April 9, 1971, and the Morgan State University Players presented *The Deal* during February 24–March 6, 1983.

Described by Jones as "a play on racism in American society," *The New Nigger* uses a play-within-a-play structure, humor, and other self-referencing devices to encourage collective action from the Black community.⁴⁴ The play opens with a violent scene of Black rebellion drawn from the imagination of a young artist named Young Black. Young Black writes, directs, and stars in the production as the charismatic, yet highly incompetent and sexist Southern leader named Reverend Freeman. Jones uses Young Black's production as a metaphor for the Black revolution, asking, "who writes the Black man's script?"⁴⁵ *The New Nigger* suggests that to "direct" a successful revolution, Black male activists must decenter hegemonic masculinity and work with Black women and girls to strategize viable solutions to white-authored shootings.

As with the revolutionaries in *The Bronx Is Next*, Young Black believes himself committed to Black liberation, but ultimately obstructs the cause by failing to envision revolution as anything more than mob violence. Jones's stage directions describe Young Black's vision of Black rebellion:

Curtain opens upon free-for-all racial melee as crowds of whites and Blacks battle, using guns, knives and all kinds of weapons. Scene is filled with violence. Suddenly police force of all whites rushes in from the back auditorium, down aisles, and onto stage, breaking up mob. Police use nightsticks, tear gas and hose in order to disperse mob violence.⁴⁶

In Young Black's vision, aggressive, militaristic, and racialized violence reigns. In this moment of chaos, Young Black does not provide audiences context for *why* the uprising is happening, the objective of the rebellion, or any sense of organizational leadership. I can only surmise that Young Black's dramatization would not inspire audiences to take similar action against police shootings. Later, Jones reveals the fallacy of Young Black's vision of Black liberation when he performs the role of Reverend Freeman, the man responsible for leading this rebellion during "The Niggers' March" to the Georgia state capitol building.

Reverend Freeman's ridiculous Black Power rhetoric centers on achieving hegemonic masculinity, and in so doing fails to promote any real sociopolitical change. During his sermon, he agitates for the right to visit the same beaches, parks, nightspots, and bars as white men.⁴⁷ He tells his enthusiastic male congregants: "Right now, we aim to enjoy what has been denied us for hundreds of years. We aim to eat, sleep and drink where our white brother has eaten, slept and drunk for - lo - these thousand years."⁴⁸ Reverend Freeman conceptualizes Black liberation as Black men achieving the same "success" as white men (that is, the ability to enjoy the same leisure activities). He concludes his impassioned speech with the rallying cry: "CLOSE THE SCHOOLS. CLOSE THE COLLEGES. THEY AREN'T ANY GOOD FOR US ANYWAY! WE'VE BEEN HANDED EDUCATION: WE'VE BEEN TALKED, WALKED AND SLEPT EDUCATION. DOWN WITH EDUCATION!"⁴⁹ As a lifelong educator, Jones clearly supported educational opportunities for Black youth. Her decision to have a Black artist create an image of

⁴⁴ Lola E. Jones, "The New Nigger, or Who's Afraid of William Faulkner," in *Exploring the Black Experience in America: Short Stories and Plays by Lola E. Jones* (Baltimore: Morgan State University Press, 1976), 58.

⁴⁵ Jones, "The New Nigger," 58.

⁴⁶ *Ibid.*, 59.

⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, 70–71.

⁴⁸ *Ibid.*, 71.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*

a preacher—traditionally seen as a leader within Black communities—decry education and promote the acquisition of white men’s leisurely activities issues a call for a radical revisioning of Black liberation. Jones ironizes Reverend Freeman’s rallying cry through a counterargument presented by a timid Black girl.

Meek Young Voice, later identified as Little Sister, challenges Reverend Freeman’s leadership and masculinist vision of liberation by asking a series of questions at the conclusion of his speech. She asks: “What about schools and colleges, sir? . . . Ain’t they important? Ain’t we gonna fight to go there, too? I mean, ain’t they just as important as . . . as the night spot?”⁵⁰ Before Little’s Sister’s questions, Black male congregants dominated the dramatized Black nationalist debate, with Black women only occasionally interjecting “Amen” or other similar affirmations. Reverend Freeman responds to Little Sister’s queries, stating that “schools and colleges will come to us in due time.”⁵¹ Borrowing from Faulkner’s plea for more “time,” he dismisses her justifiable concerns and continues with his plans.

Ultimately, Young Black’s vision of Black liberation does not include the concerns of women and girls, resulting in an asinine call-to-arms. However, Little Sister’s poignant questions position Black women and girls as more than capable of leading the revolution.

“Suicide” and Black Widowhood: Carol Freeman’s Womanist Intervention

Freeman’s *The Suicide* also privileges Black women’s subjectivity without in any way negating concern for the collective well-being of all of Black America. *The Suicide* allows audiences to witness a Black woman’s devastation brought on by the extra-legal murder of her intellectual husband. Freeman draws from Black women’s anti-lynching playwriting tradition, centering the struggle for citizenship through Wife’s experiences. Koritha Mitchell writes, “because lynching plays reflect and encourage community conversation, the emergence of the Black mother/wife as a central figure registers the degree to which her experiences informed discussions of Black identity and citizenship.”⁵² Jones draws from this genre, using the typical one-act structure, the image of a devastated Black widow, the terror of a white-authored home invasion, and denial of Black citizenship to reveal the injustice of US laws. However, in centering the pain of Black widowhood, Freeman also considers the failures of Black clergymen and the need to redefine Black liberation as the survival of the Black family.

The Suicide takes place in a hot, filthy, and cramped rented apartment in an unidentified city. The sparse set includes a bed, religious paraphernalia, and a closed casket. The one-act play begins with Neighbor pressing Wife for more information about the suspicious death of her husband, Frank Jones. As the conversation unfolds, audiences learn that Frank could not drive a car, yet managed to travel a far distance to commit suicide on a bridge where a thousand other Black men have also mysteriously died. Neighbor reports: “Newspapers jus’ say he jumped, nombah some thousan’ jumped from the bridge, didn’t hardly say much mo’.”⁵³ Suspicion of foul play intensifies when Wife reveals that Frank was “railly a good man, ‘cept readin’ o-all them books, and

⁵⁰ Ibid.

⁵¹ Ibid.

⁵² Koritha Mitchell, *Living with Lynching: African American Lynching Plays, Performance, and Citizenship, 1890–1930* (Champaign-Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2011), 148.

⁵³ Freeman, *The Suicide*, 300.

drankin' so much wine done rumn him crazy."⁵⁴ Frank's intelligence and alcohol use likely lowered his inhibitions, making him more outspoken and therefore a target for white male violence. Lacking a gun, Frank met his gruesome end at a bridge, where neither his devotion to God nor love of books offered protection. When Preacher—a "pompous man"—enters Wife's apartment under the guise of fulfilling his "Christian duty," he does not offer a prayer for Frank's soul nor question the circumstances of his death.⁵⁵ Instead, he simply stares at Frank's lynched body and stands idly by as Wife receives a beating from white police officers.

The Black Church has functioned as a powerful force for organizing Black resistance to white-authored violence, but it has also perpetuated white, middle-class ideologies that harm vulnerable members within the Black community, including women, non-binary, and LGBTQ+ folk. Historically, Black clergymen have concerned themselves with the spiritual needs of their congregations. Many more have also led the masses in protest against racial oppression, functioning as spiritual advisors, civic activists, and political leaders within their communities. Black clergymen and their congregations have cultivated a politics of respectability—a form of racial uplift ideology that includes a concern for public appearance and the adoption of Victorian mores—in the hope of gaining white acceptance. "From its position of authority, the Black Church has shown strong support for the patriarchal family, claiming that men should be the heads of the church, that women should not be preachers, and that men should rule their families," writes Collins.⁵⁶ Jones's apolitical Preacher embodies this popular conservative politics, caring more for the appearance of respectability than for galvanizing the Black community to agitate for social justice.

Freeman condemns conservative Black clergymen who fail to mourn with Black women and seek justice for all forms of white-authored violence. In *The Suicide*, Preacher's longing to view Frank's corpse supersedes his sacred responsibility to mourn with Wife. Audiences learn that Preacher has never visited the Jones's home and is, in fact, a stranger to them. Having read a report of Frank's "suicide" in the newspaper, Preacher insists he has arrived to offer a prayer. Once seated, Preacher remains silent until Wife offers to let him view Frank's body. Preacher responds, "Don't mind if I do," as casually as if he were accepting refreshments.⁵⁷ Upon viewing Frank's lynched body, Preacher stares in horror. Had he moved beyond voyeurism and fulfilled his Christian duty, Preacher might have helped her put together the suspicious circumstances of Frank's supposed "suicide." However, as a voyeur of Black trauma porn, Preacher says nothing to alleviate Wife's suffering and does nothing to incite justice.

The Suicide uses Wife's traumatic experiences during Frank's wake to condemn state-sanctioned violence against Black women. After a street fight between Wife and a neighbor draws the attention of white police officers, she reenters her apartment sporting a bruised eye, torn dress, and disheveled hair. Spectators are left to wonder if her injuries are the result of her participation in the street fight or of the police officers' violence. The officers investigate the street fight, entering Wife's home, interrogate the mourners, mishandle Wife, and make lewd comments about Black women's sexual-

⁵⁴ Ibid.

⁵⁵ Ibid., 301–2.

⁵⁶ Collins, *Black Sexual Politics*, 183.

⁵⁷ Freeman, *The Suicide*, 302.

ity. The officers' invasion of Wife's home reflects the painful reality that Black women have never been safe inside their own homes.⁵⁸ The officers embody a sadistic joy in terrorizing Wife in her home, a morbid tradition which traces back to the Jim Crow era.⁵⁹ When the officers open Frank's coffin against Wife's wishes and she demands they close the coffin to prevent flies from eating his body, Second Cop handles her roughly and hauls her off to jail for "resisting arrest." Wife's experience of loss, assault, and unwarranted arrest—compounded by Preacher's inaction—reinforces Malcolm X's famous 1962 speech in which he declared: "the most disrespected person in America is the Black woman."⁶⁰ Indeed, in the course of a single day, Wife has lost her husband, witnessed no justice for his murder, been prevented from mourning him, and lost her rights of citizenship as she joins the prison population.

Ultimately, Freeman's tragic tale raises several vital questions for Black spectators to consider: Do Black clergymen have a responsibility to seek justice for the state-sanctioned murder of Black people? How can Black communities ensure their fundamental rights as US citizens and protect Black women from state-sanctioned violence? Does Black gun ownership offer a solution to extralegal murders of Black people? Regardless of the answer, Frank's murder reflects a grim reality: we will never know what actually happened to thousands of Black men and women activists who were murdered or simply vanished during the Jim Crow and civil rights eras. *The Suicide* implicitly urges spectators to defend Black women and families and demand accountability for these murders.

The revolutionary spirit of *The Suicide* resonated with the political impulses of Black student activists at Northwestern University. *The Suicide* premiered at Black Folks's Theatre, the artistic branch of the Black student union aptly named For Members Only, in 1971.⁶¹ Inspired by Teer's theories of performance, Black Folks's Theatre members defined themselves as "liberators" who used theatre to educate, heal, and galvanize the Black Chicagoland community.⁶² Student activists realized their vision in 1971 with "The Black Portrait," an event that included productions of *The Suicide*, Sanchez's *Sister Son/ji* (1969), and Jimmy Garrett's *We Own the Night* (1968). While archival records do not explain why Black Folks's Theatre selected *The Suicide*, I surmise that the image of a mutilated Black man resting in an open casket would have evoked memories of the murder of 14-year-old Chicago native Emmett Till. Several years prior to the pro-

⁵⁸ As the fatal shooting of Breonna Taylor by Louisville police officers on March 13, 2020 can attest, Black women remain unsafe in their own homes. White, plainclothes, Louisville Metro Police Department officers named Jonathan Mattingly, Brett Hankison, and Myles Cosgrove entered 26-year-old Taylor's apartment during their drug-dealing investigation. When Taylor's boyfriend fired a warning shot, the officers returned thirty-two shots, including six which hit and killed Taylor. None of the officers were charged for Taylor's death.

⁵⁹ For example, Mitchell writes that "whites could have terrorized Blacks by shooting at them from afar, but they often preferred invading their victims' households" (148). For more information about Jim Crow-era violence inside of Black homes, see her *Living with Lynching*.

⁶⁰ Malcolm X, "On Protecting Black Women," filmed May 1962, posted April 20, 2008, YouTube, available at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6EIEKe8fVmg>.

⁶¹ For more information on Black student activism, see Biondi, *The Black Revolution on Campus*; and Ibram H. Rogers, *The Black Campus Movement: Black Students and the Racial Reconstitution of Higher Education, 1965–1972* (Basingstoke, UK: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012).

⁶² Barbara Ann Teer used the term "liberator," rather than "actor" to define the performer's role at her National Black Theatre (1968–present). For more information, see Lundean Thomas, *Barbara Ann Teer and the National Black Theatre: Transformational Forces in Harlem* (New York: Garland, 1997).

duction, a white store owner and his half-brother abducted Till from his great-uncle's home in Mississippi. They proceeded to beat, mutilate, and shoot Till in the head before throwing his body into the Tallahatchie River for allegedly making physical and verbal advances on the store owner's wife. Till's murderers were exonerated but later admitted their guilt.⁶³ Till's murder and the initial acquittal of his murderers galvanized the nation to action. The Black Folks's Theatre production captured this history, which continues today.

Echoing this terrible history, 17-year-old Trayvon Martin was also hunted, shot, and killed by a vigilante while walking back from a convenience store in Florida. Afterward, Martin's murderer admitted guilt, was acquitted, and received financial benefits by auctioning the gun used in the murder. Similar to Till's, Martin's murder has become a galvanizing force in the contemporary Black freedom struggle.

Unfortunately, *The Suicide* remains just as relevant, as Black lynchings ruled suicide persist. The summer of 2020, in particular, invoked the memory of Billie Holiday's Black protest song "Strange Fruit" (1939). Social media exploded with accounts of Black men found hanging in trees across the country. These victims include Malcolm Harsch, Dominique Alexander, Robert Fuller, and a 17-year-old boy from Texas. "Authorities say that all these deaths appear to be suicides, with no signs of foul play. But family members of the deceased, protestors and activists, and some scholars of anti-Black violence are intuitively suspicious about those conclusions," writes journalist Stacey Patton.⁶⁴ Harsch's sister, for example, remains suspicious of the suicide ruling. "My brother is 6'3. That tree was four feet. My brother was tied to a tree with an HDMI cord. Someone took their time with that knot," explains Harmonie Harsch.⁶⁵ In addition to the skepticism of Harsch, Black activists and scholars also remain doubtful of the ruling, in part because Black suicides are often misclassified.⁶⁶ Psychologists Alex Crosby and Sherry Davis Molock write:

Others have wondered whether African American suicides may be "disguised" in the form of "victim-precipitated homicides." . . . Victim-precipitated homicide is viewed essentially as an act of suicide because the victim intentionally engages in behavior in a life-threatening context that almost guarantees that another person (e.g., police officer) will kill the victim. . . . Although it has been estimated that nearly 30% of urban homicides are victim-precipitated . . . it is not formally recognized as a form of suicide.⁶⁷

By this definition, an alarmingly high number of Black homicides are brought on by behaviors that create their own death. Unfortunately, behaviors deemed "risky" for Black people, such as jogging, are everyday leisure activities for most other communities.

Furthermore, Preacher's preoccupation with Frank's corpse mirrors today's fascination with the grotesque spectacle of Black death. The use of dashcams and cell phones

⁶³ For more information about Roy Bryant and J. W. Milam's confession, see William Bradford Huie, "The Shocking Story of Approved Killing in Mississippi," *Look* 20, no. 2 (January 24, 1956): 46–48, 50.

⁶⁴ Stacey Patton, "Police Say Deaths of Black People by Hanging Are Suicides. Many Black People Aren't So Sure," *Washington Post*, June 22, 2020, available at <https://www.washingtonpost.com/outlook/2020/06/22/black-victims-hanging-suicide/>.

⁶⁵ ABC 7 Eyewitness News, "Malcolm Harsch Victorville Death: Family Demands Answers after Man Found Tied to a Tree," June 16, 2020, available at <https://abc7.com/malcolm-harsch-investigation-victorville-man-hanging-from-tree/6251244/>.

⁶⁶ Alex Crosby and Sherry Davis Molock, "Suicidal Behaviors in the African American Community," *Journal of Black Psychology* 32, no. 3 (2006): 3.

⁶⁷ *Ibid.*

have allowed everyday people to bear witness to white-authored violence. However, the footage of actual shootings of Black people also allows *anyone* to watch Black deaths from the comfort of their homes. While this footage has galvanized activists to action and in some cases used as evidence against perpetrators, the frequency and casual nature of such viewings also run the risk of stripping us of our humanity and normalizing our deaths.

Conclusion

The experiences of artists and activists of the Black Arts and Black Power era continue to offer valuable insights into the contemporary Black liberation struggle. The dramas of Sanchez, Jones, and Freeman reinforce the reality that Black liberation involves collective effort. This profound truth is evident in Baraka's recollection of the 1967 Newark Rebellion, in which he took part. Baraka recalls his personal experience of nearly being murdered by the police—if not for the help of the Black community—in his unpublished essay, "Spirit House, The New Fortress" (2013). Baraka writes:

We stayed out too late, even stopping to pick up a brother shot in the leg by the police and took him to Martland Hospital. Later he was a key witness in my trial. Since my friends and I were arrested later that evening as we had turned the car around to head home. We saw the red lights flashing, and we were stopped, pulled from the VW van and I was beaten, head split open, teeth loosened. I believe the police would have killed me except for the people in an apartment building who were witnessing the beating started hollering and throwing things.⁶⁸

From Baraka's perspective, police officers used excessive force and failed to detect actual crime. Instead, they became judges, jury, and executioners, inflicting violence on those they pledged to serve and protect. While experiences such as this demonstrate the longstanding need to reform or defund the police, his story also offers a beacon of hope. In Baraka's most desperate circumstances—when he thought he would surely die—it was the Black community of Newark that protected him. They did so by bearing witness to the crime and actively participating in his struggle, demonstrating how crucial collective action is to our survival as a people (fig. 4).

Collective action starts with recognizing that *none* of us are free until *all* of us are free. For this reason, I urge Black artists and activists to answer Charlene Carruthers's call to embrace Black queer feminist praxis as a tool of empowerment. Founded upon the theories and practices of Black feminist and LGBTQ+ activists, Black queer feminist praxis fosters the liberation of *all* Black people, regardless of gender, sexuality, age, class, and so forth by allowing "people and groups to bring their full selves into the process of dismantling all systems of oppression."⁶⁹ Carruthers writes that by using this lens, "we can more effectively prioritize problems and methods that center historically marginalized people in our communities."⁷⁰ As the revolutionary theatre of the Black Arts Movement can attest, the theatre has served as a powerful tool to disseminate such calls. We must do more to support the efforts of Black artists and activists who answer this call today.

⁶⁸ Amiri Baraka, "Spirit House, The New Fortress" (2013), in *Rise Up Newark*, available at <https://riseupnewark.com/spirit-house-the-new-fortress-by-amiri-baraka-ilovepdf-compressed/>.

⁶⁹ Charlene A. Carruthers, *Unapologetic: A Black, Queer, and Feminist Mandate for Radical Movements* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2018), 10.

⁷⁰ *Ibid.*

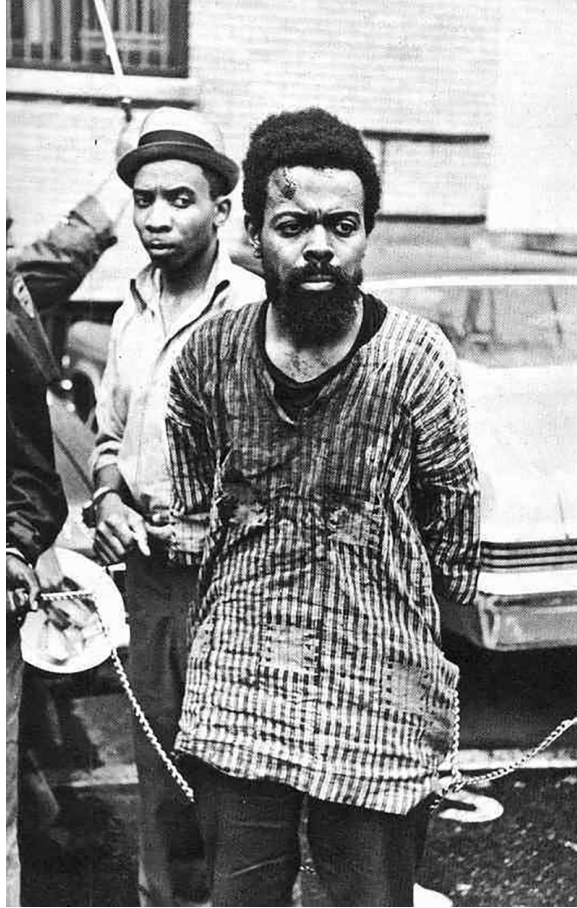


Figure 4. Amiri Baraka leaving the police station after being arrested during the Newark Rebellion on July 14, 1967. (Photo: Fred W. McDarrah, courtesy of Getty Images.)

Analyzing the more recent past serves as an important reminder that many of the gains made by Black activists and their allies have been systematically dismantled following the Black Power era. For example, many of the Black theatres founded during this era suffered financially in the waning years, with some closing long before the crippling impact of the 2020 global pandemic. How can historically Black theatres foster the next generation of artists and offer strategies to eradicate white-authored gun violence if they do not exist? In addition, civil rights protections have also been eradicated. For example, beginning in 1996, Texas, California, Washington, Florida, Michigan, Nebraska, Arizona, Oklahoma, New Hampshire, and Idaho have eliminated affirmative action policies. Black activists and their allies also fought to put Black history and culture back on the world stage, creating the first Black studies program at San Francisco State College in 1968. Juanita remembers the program offering free courses to educate Black community members. Unfortunately, the practice “got co-opted,” exemplified by the fact that today, Black studies courses reside behind the gates of the ivory tower, firmly out of reach for many Black people.⁷¹

⁷¹ Juanita, personal interview.

The erosion of civil rights protections, coupled with the ever-present threat of white male-authored shootings, attests to the urgent need to foster Black art and activism at every level of society. To put this in plain terms: the energy used to fuel the (mostly) white mob that stormed the US Capitol building on January 6, 2020, is the same energy that hung a noose around Black women and men a century ago. The energy that fuels anti-Black violence has never gone away, because in all situations—to hearken to the sentiments of Patricia Young—the perpetrators saw themselves as “agents to their white peers.”⁷² They were confident that as executioners of “justice,” they would avoid any accountability for their actions. We have lost generations of Black artists and activists to the everyday, less-sensationalized occurrence of white-authored shootings. Their premature deaths have had a profound impact on the lives of many, myself included.

Having survived abject poverty and gun violence in one of the wealthiest countries in the world, I now ask: How can Black activists and their allies use theatre as a tool to further Black liberation? The Black Arts Movement empowered everyday Black people to take action and promote a cultural revolution that would redefine what it means to be human. I hope that twenty-first-century Black activists and their allies will learn from these efforts and create art that engages the masses and fosters the inclusive aims of the Black Lives Matter movement. I stand as a witness that if we continue to lose the gains made from their activism, we will see another generation of Black youth lost to incarceration and death.

⁷²Young, “Acts of Terrorism,” 34.